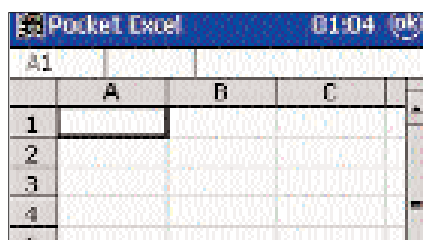




Polish up office documents on the move!

ActiveSync and a combination of certain Web services, you can download a collection of Web pages onto your Pocket PC and use the browser to view them later when you're on the go.

Funnily enough, Pocket PC features Windows Media Player, but before you get excited about it, take into account the 16 MB to 64 MB of storage space, most of which is already being used by applications. Even if you have its entire capacity at your disposal, can you really store a decent collection of videos, or even songs for



Ideally suited for simple accounting jobs

memory upgrade cards, or better still, IBM's Microdrive.

Microsoft Reader

If you like to read while travelling, you will definitely appreciate Microsoft Reader, which is designed to use e-books or electronic books. What makes this reader a nifty utility is a feature called ClearType, a way of displaying letters on the screen for maximum legibility. The text is clear and crisp and one really can't complain about too little fitting on a single page. Reader efficiently uses about 90 per cent of the screen to show the text in an e-book, so it is pretty comfortable to read despite the text being rather small. If you are interested in mobile finance, you will like Money, a small finance package for people on the move.

Ease of use

Chances are, your first brush with the Pocket PC will be marred by confusion, despite the fact that it has a friendly look and feel to it. But after you spend a few hours with the device, things will settle in a bit, and you'll be able to navigate your way through most of the basic functions such as browsing and synchronising the device with the desktop. Seasoned computer users won't take too much time getting busy with this neat little gadget. But what about those who aren't as tech-savvy?

We tossed queries at the myriad handheld users we had a chance to question. The replies were highly varied and just as subjective. However, from the feedback, it appears that the experience really depends on whether you are an optimist or a pessimist. Microsoft, you see, has gone to great lengths in getting not only its premium offerings ported, but also streamlining the code and smoothening the interface. It is heartening to know that commendable efforts such as these are being pushed into improving PDA usage. But those who are not too firmly rooted



With the Pocket version, you can easily view Web pages without requiring a special modem.

With Microsoft that matter? At best, the Pocket PC platform is suited only for small clips of audio, or for taking notes, perhaps. But if you do insist on watching movie clips and listening to MP3s, the only way to go is to purchase

Pocket PC 2002

Like a desktop computer, Pocket PCs offer a path for owners to upgrade their operating system. As of now, the only upgrade available for Pocket PC owners is Pocket PC 2002. Though most of the functionality provided with 2002 is included in the original version, users can benefit through the enhancements featured in the upgrade. The focus here seems to be on improving the look and feel of the interface and adding functionality to existing applications.

For the first time, the Pocket PC has poised itself for enterprise use. Among these corporate trimmings is built-in VPN (Virtual Private Networking), which gives you a secure connection to your company's network through the Web. In order to deploy Web-based applications on your intranet, Pocket PC 2002 features a Web server which also gives you the freedom to work when you're offline.

For other market segments, these additions may not appear to be so useful. Perhaps the sole incentive for personal users to make the switch is the introduction of a 'pocketised' MSN Messenger. But, this minor increase in usability doesn't alone justify the need for an upgrade. Like the transition from Windows 98 to Me, the road to Pocket PC 2002 looks to be yet another colourful, yet uneventful journey. At best, Pocket PC 2002 has something to offer corporations looking to buy new hardware.

Handhelds which have native support for the latest make of Pocket PC will come up with new specifications. For example, the new OS will only support devices that have chips based upon ARM technology, such as Intel's 206 MHz StrongARM processor. Upgrades to the Pocket PC 2002 are available provided they meet the new software's requirements.

in the digital age might find this a tad difficult to believe.

Data portability

Pocket PC gives us two ways of synchronising data between the device and a desktop PC—by infrared and by the wired approach. You can either connect its cradle to your PC through the USB or through the serial port, depending upon the model you choose. Microsoft's ActiveSync is a software which acts as content director between the Pocket PC and the desktop. You can select how automated the sync process should be, and coordinate everything from your calendars and contacts to e-mail and files.

Especially because we in India are still deprived of wireless access, we should be making use of the ubiquitous Web more. Through specialised services such as Avantgo, we can access anything from condensed to full-sized Web pages without a mobile Internet connection. Hundreds of Web sites (called 'channels' by Avantgo), including Anandtech and CNN, offer concise editions of Web pages



Tiny, yet clean and slick

